

Desirable Futures *with robots*



A series of distributed workshops, inventing a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for social robots — reclaiming a question that has, so far, been answered mostly outside HRI.

I From laboratory to industry.

Robotics is shifting fast. In the past three years, parts of the field — humanoid platforms most visibly, but also home, delivery, service, and care robots — have moved from laboratory subfields to industry-led races: multi-trillion-dollar market forecasts, sizeable state investment in China, South Korea, and elsewhere, and capable, increasingly affordable platforms reaching the market (Unitree's G1 humanoid at around \$16K USD is one indicator).

Within one to two years, autonomous and semi-autonomous robots — humanoid or otherwise — are expected to be present in everyday life: at home, at work, in care, in public space. HRI has a narrow window in which to shape the discourse. Practically, the next eighteen to twenty-four months.

II Efficiency. Productivity. Replacement.

The prevailing framing rests on a stable set of arguments: robots will perform jobs that are dull, dirty, or dangerous; offset labour shortages; save human time; and — most visibly through the humanoid wave — represent the next stage of the AI race, a step from text and image into *physical AI*.

*Across these arguments runs a consistent through-line: robots are positioned in **competition with humans** — on labour, on time, on capability.*

The early effects of letting this framing harden are visible in generative AI. With embodied robots — humanoid or otherwise — the same logic extends into domestic, relational, civic, and intimate domains, settings where the criteria of *efficiency* and *replacement* translate poorly.

III Reclaiming the narrative.

Without explicit debate, much of robotics has begun to converge on a narrow vision — robots as efficient surrogates for human labour, with the humanoid form as the most visible default. The convergence is largely silent: never formally decided, never ethically justified, sustained by media coverage, capital, and funding incentives.

It deserves to be examined. *Human-centred* design is not the same as *human-shaped* design — and the question is not only how to design a robot, but whether and when a robot is the right answer at all. The HRI community has a responsibility to keep these distinctions live, and, where possible, to **reclaim the narrative**.

Can we invent a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for social robots?

Each workshop opens with a *what if* that reverses one element of the dominant framing — and asks participants to imagine a desirable future growing from there.

Not dystopia. Not subversion for its own sake. A future they would actually want.

Below: the starting bank. Pick one, adapt one, or invent your own. Send new prompts back so the bank grows.

01 What if robots *didn't always say yes* to our orders?

02 What if a robot was *clumsy*, and needed our help — all the time?

03 What if a robot didn't try to *save* your time, but to *waste it well*?

04 What if a robot brought you *something you never asked for*?

ADD YOUR OWN

05 _____

06 _____

07 _____

The rationale needs translation, not simplification. Below: short notes for four common audiences. Adapt to your context, your language, your room. These are starting points, not scripts.

Children

INTRODUCE AS

A storybook framing. *"Imagine a robot who..."* Centre the robot as a character with feelings, quirks, and refusals — not a tool.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Clumsiness. Surprise gifts. A robot that doesn't always say yes. Friendship over function.

WATCH-OUTS

Avoid abstract policy framings. Avoid scary-robot tropes. Keep concrete and playful.

Adolescents

INTRODUCE AS

A speculative-design brief. *"Design the robot you would actually want — for yourself, in five years."*

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Refusal. Identity. Time-wasting (in good ways). Robots that protect rather than monitor.

WATCH-OUTS

Don't moralise. Don't anchor only to school-or-work framings. Make space for ambivalence.

Older adults

INTRODUCE AS

A conversation about everyday life and care, not technology. Start from *what works well now* and ask where a robot might fit — if at all.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Needing-help (from the robot, not toward it). Presence over function. Robots that *aren't* caregivers.

WATCH-OUTS

Avoid framings that read as condescending. The "lonely older person + companion robot" assumption deserves to be opened, not reinforced.

Workers (warehouse, care, service)

INTRODUCE AS

A frank discussion about the workplace they know — what's dignified about it, what's not, where robots are already arriving, and what a desirable shift would look like.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Co-presence rather than replacement. Robots that hand off rather than take over. Time given back, on the worker's terms.

WATCH-OUTS

Acknowledge precarity directly. Avoid techno-optimism. Be specific about who benefits and who pays in each scenario.

Each workshop should produce at least one *desirable future*, captured on the report form (page 5). Four formats below — pick the one that fits your audience, time, and space. Role-play is recommended: it places people *in* situation rather than reasoning *about* it.

RECOMMENDED

Role-play / theatre

~60 min · groups of 3–6 · low-prop, low-cost

STRUCTURE

Introduce one *what if*. Assign roles (a person, the robot, an observer). Play out a five-minute scene. Debrief. Re-play with one element changed.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

Title of the scene; who/what/where; the moment of the desirable future; what changed between runs.

Drawing

~45 min · individuals, then share · paper + pens

STRUCTURE

Introduce the *what if*. Fifteen minutes of individual sketching (the robot, the moment, the place). Round-robin share. Cluster ideas.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

One to three representative sketches with brief captions. The cluster of ideas the group recognised in common.

Speculative fictions

~60–90 min · individuals or pairs · in *writing* (a short essay or vignette) or in *art* (a painting or drawing)

STRUCTURE

Introduce one *what if*. Brief world-building together (who, where, when). Each participant then writes a short speculative vignette *or* makes one finished image of a scene from that future. Share — read aloud, or exhibit and discuss.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

The text or artwork itself (scan or photograph it); a title; one or two sentences naming the desirable future it embodies.

Scene-building

~45 min · small groups · Lego bricks, blocks, or found objects

STRUCTURE

Introduce one *what if*. Each group builds a small physical scene — a single moment from that future — with bricks, blocks, or found objects. Walk the room: each group narrates its scene. Rebuild one element and see what changes.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

A photograph of the build; a title; one or two sentences naming the desirable future it embodies.

Brainstorming

~30 min · small group · post-its or notebook

STRUCTURE

Three minutes of silent ideation. Round-robin share. Cluster on the wall or page. Vote on the two ideas the group wants to live in.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

The top two or three desirable futures with the rationale the group gave for each.

Interviews

~30 min per pair · one-on-one or pairs

STRUCTURE

Introduce the *what if*. Open-ended questions about the person's life, then about how a robot might fit (if at all). Record answers carefully.

WHAT TO CAPTURE

One to three direct quotes; the recurring concerns or hopes across interviews; the desirable future each person sketched out in their own words.

DATE	LOCATION	RESEARCHER	TARGET GROUP	FORMAT	PARTICIPANTS
				role-play, drawing, brainstorming, interview...	

What if... _____

TITLE OF THIS DESIRABLE FUTURE

SHORT DESCRIPTION

IMAGE

Sketch directly, photograph, or attach separately and reference here.

A drawing, a diagram, a photo of the workshop output — anything that helps the future feel concrete.

01 What *future* does this imagine? (Not the robot — the life around it.)

02 The robot's *role, shape, and place* in that future.

03 What does this robot *refuse* — or simply not do?

04 Why is this future *desirable*?
